

Living Through Learning (LTL) – Empowering Early Literacy in South Africa

History & Background

- **Founding:** LTL was founded by **Sonja Botha** (formerly of Education Alive) around 2010–2012 ¹ ². Botha had run *Education Alive* for 25 years and went independent in 2010 to create LTL ¹. The organization is a **registered NPO/PBO** based in Cape Town, dedicated to foundation-phase (early grade) literacy ³.
- **Evolution:** The directors brought decades of educational experience (35+ years) into LTL. Over this time they have trained 150,000+ learners and 700+ educators in literacy programs ⁴. LTL's flagship *Foundation Phase Literacy* curriculum (used by 30,000+ children) has reportedly boosted literacy scores by up to 80% ⁴ ². By 2024 their programs had helped place over 500 learners into tertiary study or the workforce ⁴.
- **Focus:** From its inception, LTL aimed to “*uplift and equip disadvantaged educators and learners with the requisite skills to succeed in schooling*” ³. It operates mainly in Cape Town township schools, addressing systemic and socio-economic literacy challenges.

Mission, Vision & Values

- **Mission:** LTL's mission is “to provide training and interventions to support educators and learners in South Africa in literacy,” giving youth “a chance to flourish in their formative schooling years” and building educators’ passion through practical training ⁵. This emphasizes hands-on pedagogy, boosting confidence and career dreams through improved reading and writing.
- **Vision:** The organization believes “every child is a national asset and every child must be able to read with meaning” ⁶. Its tagline, “*Awakening Africa through Early Literacy*”, reflects the goal of ensuring all learners can “read and write with full comprehension” ⁶.
- **Core Values:** LTL stresses a **learner-centric, outcome-driven approach**. With over 35 years of experience ⁷, it uses a proven, phonics-based methodology (based on Caleb Gattegno's *Words in Colour*) and measures both qualitative and quantitative outcomes ⁵ ⁷. Key values include passion for education, measurable impact (e.g. tracking literacy gains), and practical empowerment of teachers and learners.

Services & Offerings

- **Reading Adventure Rooms (RAR/CRAR):** LTL builds themed literacy classrooms equipped with tailored resources. For example, the *Coronation Reading Adventure Room* (CRAR) program provides a step-by-step phonics curriculum and materials (manipulatives, workbooks, games, TV media, etc.) in a vibrant “literacy room” setting ⁸ ⁹. Launched in 2010 at 4 schools, CRAR grew to 30+ schools by 2019 ¹⁰, benefiting ~3,000 learners and 105 educators per year. Participating schools report average English literacy score increases of 10–20% within a term ¹⁰.
- **Educator Training & Forums:** LTL conducts professional development for teachers. Workshops cover classroom management, communication, lesson planning, learning barriers and discipline ¹¹. They also host educator forums (growing from 30 to 250+ participants) to share best practices and address common challenges ¹². These train-the-trainer sessions embed LTL's methods in schools and help teachers eventually lead the programs themselves.

- **Curriculum Development:** Working with the WC Education Department (WCED) and other authorities, LTL has designed a **comprehensive Foundation Phase literacy curriculum**. This curriculum, aligned with CAPS standards, is used in schools to ensure systematic phonics instruction ⁸ ¹³. LTL effectively “consults” by partnering on curriculum rollout and by placing trained facilitators to implement it in classrooms.
- **Digital Literacy Initiatives:** In recent years LTL has piloted tech-enabled programs. For example, in 2023 they launched a **tablet-based literacy hub** at Levana Primary (Lavender Hill) ¹⁴. Through donations of iPads and headsets, 160+ Grade 1 pupils now rotate daily, using literacy games and e-books to complement the LTL workbook curriculum ¹⁵. Managing Director Natalie Roos explains this “bridges the gap of the digital divide” and makes learning interactive ¹⁶. LTL aims to expand such digital pilots to more schools ¹⁷ ¹⁸.
- **E-Learning Shop:** LTL offers an online **shop of educational materials**, reflecting its marketing site presence ¹⁹. Products include early literacy workbooks and motor-skill kits aligned with their pedagogy (e.g. tracing books, multi-sensory resources). This shop both promotes the curriculum and provides revenue to sustain programs.
- **Outreach & Events:** The NGO also runs literacy events (e.g. World Book Day readings, holiday programs) and donor-funded initiatives (e.g. distribution of storybooks through the Coronation “Big Read” campaign ²⁰). These support community engagement and publicity.

Target Audience & Market Positioning

- **Primary Audience:** Foundation-phase learners (Grades R–2, roughly ages 5–8) in under-resourced South African schools, especially English Second Language speakers. LTL focuses on “pupils in Cape Town schools” who struggle with reading and writing ²¹.
- **Educators and Schools:** Teachers, principals and school administrators are key partners. LTL equips these educators with training and resources. The organization positions itself as an educational partner to schools, “ignite(ing) educators’ passion” and helping them build reading skills in their classes ²² ²¹.
- **Donors & Funders:** Corporate sponsors, charitable trusts, and government agencies (notably the Western Cape Education Dept.) are major stakeholders. LTL has secured support from Coronation Fund Managers, GrandWest, Nedbank, Sali Trust, and others ²³. In marketing terms, LTL showcases these partnerships and impact to position itself as a **credible, results-driven NGO**.
- **Community & Parents:** Through events and training, LTL also engages parents and volunteers. For example, schools note that parental involvement (reading to children at home) is encouraged as part of the program ²⁴.
- **Positioning:** LTL brands itself as a **pioneering literacy NGO**: one news profile calls it a “non-profit organisation” creating “magical” learning spaces ²⁵. Its messaging highlights proven outcomes (e.g. “increases literacy rates by up to 80%” ¹³) and unique learning environments. By emphasizing quantitative successes and vivid classroom experiences, LTL aims to stand out among education NGOs and secure funding/support.

Current Strategy & Future Goals

- **Scaling Programs:** LTL is actively expanding its footprint. Recent press notes two new literacy rooms (e.g. West End Primary in Mitchells Plain) funded by Minrath Trust ⁹. They plan to introduce similar rooms in more schools with corporate backers (Coronation and GrandWest remain key partners).
- **Digital Expansion:** The organization explicitly intends to scale up its digital literacy work. The 2023 tablet lab pilot “will be expanded to other schools,” with LTL working closely with teachers

to refine the program ¹⁸. This aligns with a broader strategy to modernize resources and reach tech-savvy youth.

- **Universal Literacy Goal:** On a program level, LTL has set ambitious targets. For example, one facilitator expressed confidence that “by the end of the year, all our Grade 1s will be able to read” ²⁶. Achieving this would demonstrate mastery of their foundation curriculum.
- **Teacher Empowerment:** Future strategy also focuses on sustainability: training teachers to eventually **lead the programs themselves**. Current facilitators mentor educators with the aim that schools can maintain RARs independently.
- **Strengthening Partnerships:** LTL continues to deepen ties with the WCED and funders. For instance, teacher training forums now involve WCED curriculum advisors ²⁷. By positioning itself as a reliable partner to government and industry, LTL secures the resources to grow.

Examples of Past Work & Success Stories

- **Literacy Room Launches:** LTL’s projects have been highlighted in local media. In April 2024 they opened an “Under the Seas” Reading Adventure Room at Perivale Primary (Lotus River) with Coronation support ²⁸. In June 2025 a *West End Primary* room was launched via Minrath Trust, complete with threading beads, playdough, storybooks and interactive equipment ²⁹ ³⁰.
- **Impact Metrics:** Principals report dramatic results. West End’s principal noted that LTL’s foundation-phase curriculum has “produced remarkable results – increasing literacy rates by up to 80% and helping over 500 pupils transition into tertiary education and into meaningful employment” ³¹. These figures mirror LTL’s own tracked outcomes.
- **Teacher & Student Feedback:** Testimonials consistently praise LTL’s approach. Educators report that students who once could not write now trace letters and engage eagerly in reading exercises ³¹ ³². One teacher observed that learners “experience more success, which in turn plays a big role in their self-esteem” ³¹. LTL facilitators like Clarice Joubert receive commendations for making literacy “fun” and confidence-building ³³ ³⁴.
- **Notable Clients/Partners:** Key supporters include **Coronation Fund Managers** (long-term sponsor of CRAR), **GrandWest Casino and Entertainment** (Wild About Reading rooms), as well as trust donors like Sali, Nedbank, Ackerman and others ²³. LTL is also listed as a partner by the Western Cape Education Department ³⁵. These alliances have enabled large-scale initiatives (e.g. distribution of 25,000 storybooks via Coronation’s literacy campaigns ²⁰).

Website Recommendations

To reflect LTL’s **brand identity and mission**, the new website should be clear, inspirational and action-oriented. Key insights include:

- **Highlight Impact:** Lead with mission-driven messaging and metrics (e.g. “30,000+ learners taught, literacy up 80%” ⁴). Use banners or infographics to showcase results and “Awakening Africa through Early Literacy” themes.
- **Showcase Programs Visually:** Use photos of colorful reading rooms and engaged children (as seen on their site and in press) to convey vibrancy. Accompany program descriptions (CRAR, forums, digital labs) with brief outcomes.
- **Easy Calls-to-Action:** Make “Donate”, “Volunteer”, and “Buy our Materials” prominent. For example, link to the **E-Learning Shop** (currently on the homepage) ¹⁹ and a donation platform (Forgood).
- **Credibility & Partners:** Feature logos of supporting donors (Coronation, GrandWest, WCED, etc.) and testimonials from educators/principals. This builds trust with potential funders.
- **Mobile-Friendly & Accessible:** Many users (teachers, parents) may access via phones. The site should be fast and easy to navigate, with clear menus.

- **Resource Hub:** Include a “Resources” or “News & Events” section (newsletters, media coverage, educational tips) to keep stakeholders informed.

Suggested Website Sections

Section	Purpose
Home	Brief intro to LTL’s mission and impact; highlight latest programs and a strong call-to-action (e.g. donate or get involved).
About Us	Organization history, mission/vision statements, and team bios (showing founder Sonja Botha and leadership). Provides credibility and context.
Programs / Services	Detail each core offering (e.g. Reading Adventure Rooms, Educator Training, Digital Lab, E-learning Shop). Explain <i>how it works</i> and who it helps.
Impact & Success	Share statistics (learners trained, literacy gains), case studies and testimonials from schools/principals/teachers. Demonstrate effectiveness.
Get Involved	Clear information on donating, volunteering, corporate sponsorship, and partnerships. Include donation links and contact for donors.
Shop / Materials	Direct link to the online E-Learning Shop; explain how materials support literacy at home or in schools.
News & Events	Latest updates: news articles, newsletters, media events, blogs on literacy trends. Keeps the site fresh and informative.
Contact	Contact form and details for LTL (email, phone, address), as well as social media links (Facebook, Instagram, YouTube) for community engagement.

Each section should reinforce LTL’s vision (“**every child a reader**”) and make it easy for educators, donors, and community members to engage with the organization.

Sources: Information drawn from LTL’s official website and recent news coverage ^{1 13 32 16}, including mission and history from LTL materials and program results as reported in Cape Town media.

^{1 4 5 6 22} our Vision and Mission at Living through Learning
<https://livingthroughlearning.org.za/about/vision-and-mission/>

^{2 3 7 19} Living through Learning | Awakening Africa through education
<https://livingthroughlearning.org.za/>

^{8 10} Coronation Reading Adventure Room (CRAR) - Living Through Learning
<https://livingthroughlearning.org.za/current-projects/coronation-reading-adventure-room-crar/>

^{9 13 21 24 26 29 30 33} West End Primary launches new literacy room
<https://plainsman.co.za/news/2025-06-03-west-end-primary-launches-new-literacy-room/>

^{11 12 27} Educator Training and Forums - Living Through Learning - LTL
<https://livingthroughlearning.org.za/current-projects/educator-training-and-forums/>

^{14 15 16 17 18} Literacy goes digital at Levana Primary School
<https://southernmail.co.za/news/2023-05-24-literacy-goes-digital-at-levana-primary-school/>

20 Special Event Archives - Living Through Learning - LTL

<https://livingthroughlearning.org.za/category/special-events/>

23 35 The Living Through Learning Donors & Partners

<https://livingthroughlearning.org.za/about/vision-and-mission/our-donors/>

25 28 32 34 Cape Flats skool gets a reading room

<https://dailyvoice.co.za/news/2024-04-24-cape-flats-skool-gets-a-reading-room/>

31 Success stories with Living through Learning

<https://livingthroughlearning.org.za/success-stories/>